



THIS IS TECHNOLOGY,
CULTURE AND SCIENCE
WITH A DIFFERENCE,
AND THAT DIFFERENCE
IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO
MAKE MOST NORMAL
PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

The other side

THIS MONTH WE KICK IT OFF ON THE RIGHT KEY by telling you all about mechanical keyboards, before moving on to our take on healthcare in a world where we are cyborgs. Infophilia takes you on a cryptocurrency ride, while DGT brings in some Computex, Kickstarter and Bentley goodness.

Why are eggs round? Or symmetrical? Or bottom-heavy?

Generally, eggs are ovoid, but they also come in all shapes and sizes. Many hypotheses have been put up to explain exactly what has driven this variation, with many accepting life history of different species or nesting explanations. This may be a result of the years of evolution brought out by different bird's ability to fly or adapt to certain conditions.

Over the years, scientists have come up with many explanations like, why birds with low calcium diet tend to make round eggs as they require lesser shell material, or how birds that lay eggs on cliffs and high altitude tends to be more bottom-heavy so they don't roll off edges.

But researchers from Princeton and Harvard have a different explanation to the study. According to them, egg shapes aren't influenced by what the bird eats



or how big their clutch is, but rather by how good they are at flying. The team built a custom computer program that allowed them to collect and analyse the shape of various kinds of eggs, and using this information to build a map of eggs across different bird lineages, where they make their nest, size, and how good they are at flying. Learn more: <http://dgit.in/EggShapeonths>.

Erasing a snail's memory

New study of snail neurons explains how it is possible to wipe out specific memories in snails and scientists think that one day, the same could be done to humans using drugs. In the study, researchers from McGill University could selectively erase certain kinds of memories on a marine snail. They found the memories are maintained by mainly two different types of Protein Kinase M (PKM) molecules, and by blocking one of these molecules, they could decide which memory to block. Memory maintenance in the brain is moderated by synapses that allow neurons to pass signals along one another. The properties of the synapses can increase or decrease in strength and that is how some memories last longer than others. And according to Samuel Schacher, a professor of neuroscience, by understanding this, we are able to reverse these long term changes in synaptic strength to contribute to different forms of memories.

<http://dgit.in/Snailm>

